

Mr Twitter's Diary

March 16: Makes a huge difference to discuss with Francophone African leaders in French. Only catch: I have to translate for our notetakers afterwards.

Feb 15: Launched a satirical book on Kerala politics in Mavelikara. Lamented lack of political humour by telling one of Gandhiji's jokes. No one laughed.

Jan 22: Taking off. All these journeys and the fulltime schedules involved leaving no space for another important journey, into yourself. No time introspect.

Jan 12: Fringe role of a minister in Delhi seems to be to launch books. Have now released more books than I've written!

Jan 2: Would feel better if I hadn't been roused by a loudspeaker blaring devotional songs at 5 a.m. I believe in silent prayer, not inflicting piety!

Jan 2: Great experience flying in on the prime minister's plane, just 3 hours and 10 minutes to Trivandrum, my shortest journey home. We must attract direct flights but airlines say unviable.

Dec 22, 2009: Greetings from Udaipur where my NY-based wife and I have escaped for my only week of leave this year. Tweets will be less frequent if she has her way.

Dec 18, 2009: Lok Sabha adjourned three times in a row as MPs shouted protests. As a new MP I'd have preferred a debate on the issues they were shouting about.

Dec 3, 2009: Not sure whether Delhi will destroy my sanity or my waistline first!

Nov 19, 2009: Do I have a "pendant for controversy" or does the media have a pendant for creating controversies of my innocuous remarks?

YASBANT NEGI/www.indiatodayimages.com



THAROOR WITH PRIME MINISTER MANMOHAN SINGH

new political party." It was a poor joke but even poorer was the attempt to distance the prime minister from the IPL controversy. However, on his return to India, Manmohan made it clear that he had not only familiarised himself with India's most infamous acronym but also had been enlightened of Tharoor's role in it. On April 14, while he was breakfasting in his suite at the Willard Intercontinental in Washington, the prime minister was handed a thick file of press clippings. "Is this about my visit?" he enquired only to be told that this one was about Tharoor. Thanks to Tharoor, the file with the clipping of Manmohan's visit was much slimmer.

After going through the file, he called up Principal Secretary T.K.A. Nair to get a 'factual' report on Tharoor ready. Intelligence Bureau (IB) Director Rajiv Mathur was asked to prepare the report. The PMO also sought the Finance Ministry's views on the investigations by the Enforcement Directorate and Income Tax department into the IPL. When the prime minister landed in India on April 17, his officials handed him an envelope that sealed Tharoor's fate. According to well-placed sources, the IB report detailed not only Tharoor's close monitoring of the Kochi IPL bid but also how he had negotiated for a 'sweat equity' for his lady love, Sunanda Pushkar. It highlighted Tharoor's one-time proximity to IPL Commissioner Lalit Modi and included a dossier of SMSes sent by him to the latter in the run up to the bidding process. It was the digital word

that proved to be Tharoor's undoing, for according to a PMO official, these SMSes belied his claim that he had merely 'mentored' the Kochi franchise. "The frequency and timing of these messages were a big give away about how keenly the minister was following the bid," said an official. The IB had also prepared a Plus One dossier on Sunanda, Tharoor's favourite accessory in New Delhi's social and cricketing circles. One of his SMSes to Modi is said to have referred to Sunanda's sweat equity while another refers to his aide Jacob Joseph as J. The SMS says that J would deal with the IPL bosses on the Kochi franchise.

Already briefed about this, the Congress core group was waiting for the prime minister to issue the execution orders. A great believer in propriety, Sonia Gandhi did not want to give the Opposition another excuse to talk about a Super PMO at 10 Janpath. Tharoor had two meetings with the prime minister. In the first, Manmohan patiently heard his minister who had blamed Modi for misleading him and claimed that all he had wanted was a cricket team for Kerala. At the end of Tharoor's impassioned defence, the prime minister is believed to have told him that he would let him know what needed to be done next. Later that day, Manmohan met the Congress core